

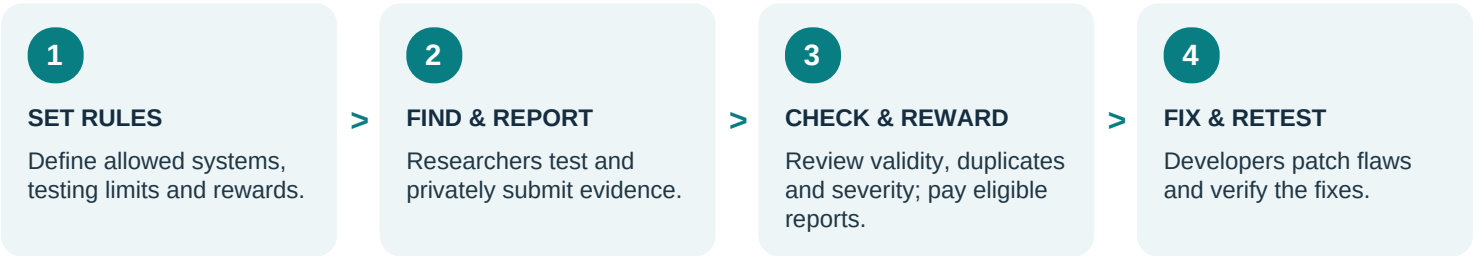
BUG BOUNTY

Outside expertise. Better security.

A decision guide for George Everett, MeCo Senior Developer

HOW IT WORKS

A company offers rewards to researchers who responsibly report eligible security vulnerabilities in approved systems. Payment depends on program rules and a validated finding. [1, 2]



ADVANTAGES [1, 2]

Fresh perspectives
Diverse researchers can find flaws internal teams or automated scans miss.

Ongoing discovery
Testing can continue as applications and services change.

Results-based rewards
Bounty payments go to qualifying findings; reports help prioritize repairs.

DISADVANTAGES [1, 2]

Staff workload
Duplicate or invalid reports still take time to review and communicate about.

Costs beyond rewards
MeCo must budget for triage, fixes and any platform or service fees.

Testing and coverage limits
Testing can disrupt systems without clear rules; no program finds every flaw.

WHO USES BUG BOUNTIES?

MICROSOFT [3]

Software & cloud

Bounty programs for eligible products and services.

GOOGLE [4]

Internet & technology

Bug Hunters connects researchers to reward programs.

PAYPAL [5]

Financial technology

Monetary awards for significant security findings.

RECOMMENDATION FOR MeCo

Start with an invitation-only pilot, narrow scope, a reward budget and named staff to review and fix reports. Expand when ready; keep secure development and internal testing. [1, 2]

REFERENCES | Numbered citations match the sections above; titles are clickable.

1. HackerOne. (2021, October 6). *Bug bounty benefits: Why you need a bug bounty program*.

2. HackerOne. (2025, December 4). *What are bug bounties and how do they work?*

3. Microsoft. (n.d.). *Microsoft bounty programs*.

4. Google. (n.d.). *Google Bug Hunters*.

5. PayPal. (n.d.). *Security policy*. paypal-identity-components. GitHub.

6. OpenAI. (2026). *Codex [AI assistant]*. Used September 20, 2026.

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AI assistance disclosure: OpenAI Codex helped locate sources, drafted and summarized the content, and designed and generated this infographic. [6]